New Kingdom Egypt and the (Southern) Levant: A Sociohistorical Overview

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Introduction

The New Kingdom spans from the reunification of Egypt at the beginning of the 18th dynasty in the mid-16th century BCE to the 20th dynasty in the mid-11th century BCE, corresponding roughly to the Late Bronze Age in Levantine terms. This period was significant for Egypt's interactions with the Near East. It is impossible to cover everything about this period in a single chapter – a whole book would be needed. Instead, I will structure this chapter around a series of key questions. First, I will address biases shaping modern views of the region. After a brief historical overview, I will examine Egyptian administration in the Levant, local perceptions of Egyptian presence, and the motivations behind Egypt's control. I will also discuss the ideological frameworks used by Egypt in these interactions and the sociocultural landscape of the region, as portrayed in the available sources. Finally, I will touch on the end of the New Kingdom and the collapse of Egyptian dominance.

Egypt and the Southern Levant during the Late Bronze Age: a Biased Story

The study of Egyptian-Levantine relations in the Late Bronze Age has been notably biased, leaning disproportionately towards the Southern Levant. This bias is rooted in a combination of biblical and Western colonial[1] perspectives that have shaped scholars' views of the region for the past 150 years, if not more, consciously or unconsciously permeating the sociocultural environment of Western scholars, and thus influencing various aspects of research and shaping our understanding of the historical dynamics of the region (see e.g. Glock 1995; Lamie 2007; see also more in general Pollock and Bernbeck 2005). The bias becomes particularly evident when we look at the distribution of archaeological digs in the region (Glock 1995, 50–53), as the Southern Levant has witnessed a disproportionate number of excavations compared to the north, and this even though the northern areas have often yielded impressive finds (see e.g. Ugarit, Qatna, Byblos, Sidon, etc.). The issue extends also to historiography and research in general, where the Southern Levant garners more attention, resulting in a plethora of scholarly publications, often influenced, directly or indirectly, by biblical associations. One could even argue that the modern classification of the "Southern Levant" as a distinct region, while convenient for academic discourse, potentially distorts our comprehension of the historical realities we are trying to study. This classification imposes a contemporary, artificial distinction on an ancient geo-cultural landscape that was likely both very fluid and simultaneously marked by borders and divisions that were different from those we are imposing on it today.

Such biases, while often overlooked, pose real challenges to our understanding of the Egypt-Levantine relations during the Late Bronze Age. In particular, while from these perspectives the Southern Levant inevitably appears as a focal point, there are compelling reasons to question this portrayal. As a start, resources like Lebanese wood and major trading routes, both north-south along the coast and through the Beqaa Valley, as well as east-west through the Gap of Homs, make the economic value and strategic centrality of the northern Levant rather evident

[1] The very distinction between the "northern" and "southern" Levant in archaeological scholarship mirrors the boundaries of the British and French mandates after World War I. Within the southern Levant, academic focus is further divided between the territories west and east of the Jordan River, following another artificial line drawn by British colonial authorities.

— something that the Egyptians were certainly not oblivious to. This is corroborated by the Egyptian sources from this period, which consistently emphasize the prominence of the Northern Levant. For instance, in the Amarna Letters—a corpus of diplomatic correspondence dating to the late 18th dynasty—interactions between Egyptian pharaohs and northern great powers and northern local rulers are prominent (out of 350 letters and related inventories, 44 come from northern great powers, at least 182 come from northern local rulers, while the remaining are either related with southern rulers or of unclear origin - Moran 1992, xiii–xxxix). Moreover, despite the Battle of Megiddo did occur in the south, subsequent Egyptian military campaigns and diplomatic efforts predominantly centered on the north for most of the New Kingdom, underscoring Egypt's sustained interest in that part of the region. Egyptian interactions with the Levant seem to have favored the north even before the New Kingdom, as recent studies of Levantine sherds in Avaris reveal predominantly northern origins for imported pottery (Mourad 2021, 45–72).

Acknowledging and addressing this bias, thus reassessing the assumptions and artificial distinctions shaping our approach to the region's history, is crucial to move away from colonial and bible-centered narratives and to reach a more balanced (and hopefully accurate) picture of the historical reality. One way to achieve this, the one adopted in this chapter, is to shift from narrative-specific inquiries to more fundamental and generic questions that span the entire Levantine socio-cultural landscape during the Late Bronze Age. By embracing a broader and more neutral perspective we can better highlight what the evidence actually shows and tells us, and we can thus obtain a more nuanced and meaningful understanding of the dynamics that characterized Egyptian-Levantine interactions at the time.

Historical Summary[2]

The reunification of Upper and Lower Egypt likely began in the mid-16th century under Kamose or his father Seqenenre Tao, but it was Kamose's successor, Ahmose I, who completed it by conquering Avaris, the Hyksos capital. After this, Egyptian kings turned their attention to the north. Ahmose I and his successors likely fought in the Levant, establishing a presence near Gaza and Tell el-Ajjul/Sharuhen. In this period, Egypt's military activities were mainly brief, ephemeral raids, though Thutmose I led campaigns as far as the Euphrates (Ahrens 2015). Due to the lack of evidence of any sustained presence beyond Gaza/Sharuhen, it has been suggested that during this early phase Egypt's focus was primarily on the northern Levant (Höflmayer 2015). Egypt established a permanent presence in the region beyond Gaza only under Thutmose III (Cline and O'Connor 2006). His campaigns (see Redford 2003) began in the 23rd year of his reign (around 1457 BCE) with the Battle of Megiddo, where he defeated a Levantine coalition led by the ruler of Qadesh. This victory secured Megiddo, consolidated control over the southern Levant, and became the prelude to a series of campaigns that resulted in Egypt conquering territories as far as northern Lebanon. These campaigns triggered a direct confrontation with the Mitannian empire/confederacy (Cancik-Kirschbaum, Brisch, and Eidem 2014), with raids deep into Syria.

Mitanni thus became Egypt's main enemy, but things changed again under Amenhotep II, Thutmose III's successor (Der Manuelian 1987). Despite a few early campaigns, Amenhotep II's reign ultimately led to a peace agreement with Mitanni. This diplomatic achievement, which included his marriage to a Mitannian princess, ushered in a period of stability lasting about 100 years, likely peaking under Amenhotep III (O'Connor and Cline 1998). During this time, the Egyptian influence extended to northern Lebanon, including the Akkar plain and the

[2] There are countless articles and books on New Kingdom Egypt. A recent example, which could serve as a basic reference for interested readers, is Radner, Moeller, and Potts 2022.

Gap of Homs[3]– the most strategic route connecting the Mediterranean to Inner Syria. However, the following Amarna Period, marked by Akhenaten's religious reforms and subsequent internal struggles, led to a weakening of the Egyptian state and its influence abroad. Moreover, an increasingly expansionist Hittite Empire, coupled with the weakening of Mitanni, fueled instability in the Northern Levant. The erosion of the Egyptian control was most evident in northern Lebanon, which saw the emergence of the kingdom of Amurru and its eventual secession from Egypt to become a vassal of the Hittites (Singer 1991). The Hittite triumph over Mitanni and the rise of Horemheb's 19th Dynasty marked a new era. Horemheb's reforms set the stage for fresh Egyptian attempts to reconquer Amurru, continued by Seti I (Murnane 1990) and Ramses II (Guidotti and Pecchioli Daddi 2002) in the 13th century BCE. The Battle of Qadesh between Ramses II and Hattusili III marked the zenith of this era. Although it changed little geopolitically, the two powers later signed a peace treaty, which led to a new period of regional stability. The 12th century BCE marked the decline of the Egyptian control over the Levant. While the details of the Bronze-Iron Age transition are debated, it is clear that both internal and external factors played a role in significantly reshaping the region's geopolitical and socio-cultural landscape (Cline 2014).

The Egyptian Administration in the Levant

While it is clear that during the New Kingdom Egypt controlled much of the Levantine coast up to southern Syria (e.g. Morris 2005), there is ongoing debate about the nature of this domination and the appropriate word(s) to refer to it—hegemony, empire, colonial control, or none of these. Addressing these terminological issues is beyond this chapter's scope, as the problem is largely a matter of understanding and misunderstanding of modern methodology, epistemology, metalanguage and historiography, and of differing uses, traditions and definitions, rather than an actual historical issue. What is clear is that throughout most of the New Kingdom, Egypt claimed domination over parts of the Southern and Northern Levant, particularly the coast up to Northern Lebanon. This domination was recognized by local rulers and by other Great Kings, such as the Mitannian and Hittite kings. Whether we call this "hegemony", "empire", or "super-mega-domination extravaganza" is, I believe, secondary.

More relevant is how Egyptian control was implemented on the ground. There is no evidence of a permanent Egyptian presence in the Levant before Thutmose III, except in the south at Tell el-Ajjul/Sharuhen. While some campaigns in the Northern Levant are recorded, Egyptian troops likely arrived by sea, bypassing the southern Levant (Höflmayer 2015, 202).

Thutmose III's conquests led to more consistent Egyptian control up to northern Lebanon (Redford 2003). Egyptian sources have been used to argue that the area was divided into "provinces", but the evidence is very ambiguous (De Magistris 2024 with refs). The Amarna letters provide better insights, showing that at the time the Egyptian administration was embodied by commissioners acting as liaisons between the Pharaoh and the local rulers. As De Magistris (2024) recently argued, looking at the origins of the letters mentioning commissioners helps identify the regions they oversaw and provides insights into Egypt's evolving administration. In particular, he identifies four areas (Gaza, Bet-Shean, Sumur, Kumidi) and notes that commissioners could be reassigned to different areas throughout their careers. He also suggests that only three centres were active at once, with Kumidi replacing Sumur in the final years of the Amarna period (De Magistris 2023a). This aligns with my earlier suggestion that Byblos was replaced by Sumur as an Egyptian centre before the Amarna period (Kilani 2017, 134–35). These changes in the Egyptian administration show that Egypt's approach to the region was very dynamic, adapting to new challenges and shifts in circumstances.

[3]It has been suggested that Ugarit may have been part of the Egyptian dominions, but the evidence is limited and contested, pointing to at most a loose relationship (Singer 1999, 621–27).

Furthermore, the fact that such changes are evident only in the north, despite the Amarna corpus covering the entire Levant, highlights the importance of these northern territories in Egypt's international strategy.

At the same time the Amarna evidence should not be overestimated: while the system of commissioners offers insights at a specific point in time, it does not reflect the entire administration throughout the whole New Kingdom and it would be wrong to projected it onto earlier or later periods, as the reality of the Egyptian domination must have been changing multiple times over the centuries. Moreover, it is clear that the picture emerging from the Amarna letters and embodied by the commissioners represents only a fraction of the contemporary Egyptian administration in the region. For example, we know from other sources (see Morris 2005 for a detailed overview) that Egyptian garrisons were present in Levantine cities and fortresses that did not host Egyptian commissioners during the Amarna period. For instance, Ullassa, possibly near Tripoli in Lebanon, hosted an Egyptian garrison in the time of Thutmose III and continued to do so during the Amarna period (Kilani 2017, 129–34). Another case is Jaffa, which had Egyptian military structures attested archaeologically (Burke et al. 2017) and was mentioned in papyrus Anastasi I, a text dating no earlier than Ramses II's reign (Fischer-Elfert 1986, 212–22). Sparse references in Egyptian texts and a few local steles suggest that Tyre played a notable role in Ramses II's campaigns leading up to the Battle of Qadesh (Kilani 2017, 109). Fortresses known as the Way of Horus secured the road along the northern coast of the Sinai Peninsula (De Magistris 2023b). Written sources mention also additional fortresses named after various kings. The 19th dynasty provides also archeological evidence for Egyptian-style governor residences, as seen in Bet-Shean (Budka 2001) or Tel Aphek (Kokhavi and Tadmor 1990), while no comparable structure is attested for earlier periods. The Annals of Thutmose III record yearly equipment of Levantine "harbors", implying established infrastructure to support a maritime route (Redford 2003, 56–61, 328; Kilani 2017, 108–9). Finally, also temples played an economic role in the Egyptian administration in the Levant (Morris 2015b), collecting (and redistributing?) taxes and tributes. Texts refer to Egyptian temples in Gaza and Byblos (Wimmer 1990; 1998; Kilani 2017, 37–49, 87–93) and a remarkable shrine has been found at the mining site of Serabit al Khadim (Mumford 2006). Notably, while Gaza may have had both a temple and a commissioner, this correlation is absent in other centers, which suggests they were part of two distinct administrative networks. All this evidence points to a complex administrative infrastructure that was conceived to cover diverse political, military, and economic domains, and which changed and adapted to new realities and new needs over time.

In this diachronic perspective, the transition from the 18th to the 19th dynasty appears to mark a significant moment of deep restructuring in Egyptian domination over the region (Morris 2005, 269–76 and passim). The most remarkable feature is a reduced reliance on local Levantine actors during the 19th dynasty, matched by an increase in more genuinely Egyptian administrative practices. The introduction of Egyptian-style governor residences at this time is a good example of this development (Morris 2005, passim). Similarly, the widespread use of hieratic in the Levant during the 19th dynasty (Levy 2017), in contrast to its general absence during the 18th dynasty, along with the complete lack of evidence for the use of cuneiform in the 19th dynasty Egyptian administration in the Levant,[4] in contrast with its prominence in the 18th dynasty,[5] might also suggest a shift from possibly pre-existing Levantine cuneiform-based scribal and administrative practices during the 18th dynasty, to more Egyptian, hieratic-based ones during the 19th dynasty (though potential archaeological preservation issues warrant caution). This also correlates well with an increase in archaeological evidence for non-prestigious Egyptian cultural practices, indicating a growing presence in the southern Levant

[4]Although cuneiform was still used for international communication (cf. Ramses II's correspondence with the Hittites).

[5]As attested by the Amarna letters and by local finds in Egyptian-controlled Taanak and Kumidi.

of individuals from Egypt or acculturated in Egypt (Streit 2019 - we still lack comparable studies for the northern Levant).
It has been argued that the origins of this shift between the 18th and 19th dynasties may be traced back to a series of reforms during the time of Horemheb (Morris 2005, 269–76 and passim). These reforms aimed to reorganize the army, making it more self-sufficient and less reliant on the resources of the Egyptian regions and villages it passed through. While the sources mainly focus on the impact of these reforms within Egypt, it is reasonable to assume that their scope was broader and may have involved also the Egyptian administration of the Levant. At the same time the episodes of the successful emergence of Amurru in the north of Lebanon (Singer 1991; Goren, Finkelstein, and Naʾaman 2003) and the failed revolt of Labayu in the southern Levant (Arie 2016), recorded by the Amarna letters, suggest a relatively loose Egyptian involvement in local politics during the late 18th dynasty, and underscore the contemporary presence of local actors who were both capable and willing to challenge the established Egyptian-sanctioned geopolitical order. This instability might have also played a role in the Egyptian change of strategy.

Local Perceptions and Receptions of the Egyptian Presence

How did local populations view the Egyptian presence in the Levant? Despite the lack of direct sources giving voice to local people, it is clear that the Egyptian presence left several traces in the region, some of which endured long after the New Kingdom. For instance, the use of hieratic numeric notations in the Iron Age Southern Levant suggests that local administrators adopted and adapted at least some Egyptian administrative practices (Wimmer 2022). However, many of these Egyptian influences were part of wider macroregional interactions that extended beyond the time and space of the New Kingdom Egyptian dominance. Additionally, several of these elements were significantly reinterpreted and independently reshaped. For instance, the emergence of non-cuneiform scripts in the Late Bronze Age/Iron Age Levant may have been influenced by Egyptian scribal practices, but native scripts evolved distinctly from hieroglyphs (Na'aman 2020). Egyptian loanwords in Levantine languages support this view (Kilani 2022): the limited number of borrowings, mainly in luxury, military, and administrative domains, indicate that while Egyptians were politically dominant, their impact on local culture was minimal, targeting only specific areas tied to their own interests. In essence, there is little evidence of widespread Egyptianization or large-scale immigration of Egyptians in the Levant. Instead, as noted by various scholars (e.g. Higginbotham 2000), the evidence points to acculturation and elite emulation, where local ruling classes selectively adopted prestigious Egyptian cultural elements, integrating them into their own traditions. This adoption appears also selective, indicating strong cultural agency and awareness among local actors. As Amel Bouhafs (2021) recently argued, even in Byblos, a centre with long-standing ties to Egypt, the adopted Egyptian elements were limited to a few items, practices, and motifs mainly associated with kingship, royal power, and specific religious realities.
It is also important to stress that this fascination with Egyptian cultural elements was not limited to the New Kingdom or the Levant. For instance, pre-New Kingdom Byblos already showed strong Egyptian influence, while Hathoric motifs are attested in the Late Bronze Age also on Cyprus and in the Aegean. Additionally, this influence was not consistent within the Levant. Sites like Byblos and Lachish show more evidence of Egyptian emulation than places like Kumidi, possibly due to the presence or absence of Egyptian personnel in different regions (Streit 2019). Finally, sites like Jaffa may have seen active resistance from local populations to Egyptian cultural influences, especially toward the end of the period (Burke et al. 2017).
These considerations mainly apply to periods of peace and are primarily connected with the experiences of the Levantine ruling classes, who were the primary producers of the sources we have access to. However, these elites represented only a small and likely exceptionally

privileged segment of the population. Unfortunately, the voices of the vast majority of the local communities were never recorded. Nevertheless, it is important to recognize that their lives were also deeply impacted by the Egyptian domination, often through destruction, oppression, and suffering. Egyptian wars were not fought in a vacuum in uninhabited deserts - in spite of the propaganda of many who tried to conquer them across the ages, those regions were never lands without peoples. While the extent and nature of the impact of Egyptian campaigns in the Levant remains debated,[6] it is clear that these campaigns were certainly deeply traumatic for the people inhabiting the region. Recent estimates points to massive numbers of prisoners of war being captured, uprooted from their communities, and deported to Egypt (Langer 2021; Matić 2021, 87–112). There is little doubt that the Egyptians engaged in acts of brutality during their military campaigns and occupation (Muhlestein 2015, 8). The Ramesside depictions of severed hands and phalli, the rather telling sign of an impaled man used to describe executed enemies in Merenptah's inscriptions, Amenhotep II's proud description of the execution of defeated rulers from Takhsi (northern Lebanon) and the display of their bodies in Egypt and Nubia, or the branding of prisoners of war under Ramses III likely represent just the tip of an iceberg of violent repression and brutality. Non-combatant individuals were also affected by these Egyptian practices. Woman deserve special attention (see Matić 2021, 87–112): while their voices are largely absent from contemporary sources,[7] the fates of some of them can be discerned between the lines. These include princesses exchanged as diplomatic tokens (Schulman 1979), and women captured in northern Levantine cities and deported to serve the Egyptian viceroy of Kush (Gaál 1976), and Papyrus Anastasi I (25:3-5) may allude to prostitution (or even rape) in the context of Egyptian military bases in the Levant. While far less visible than battles, trade, and cultural exchanges, and harder to assess due to the marginality of those affected, this darker side of the Egyptian conquests was also a part of the experience of the people of the region.

What were the Egyptians looking for?

The next question arises naturally: What were the interests driving the Egyptian efforts to control the Levant? This question has sparked intense debate, with no solution in sight. In my view, seeking a single answer may be an illusory endeavour, as the New Kingdom Egyptian domination was an intrinsically complex phenomenon that involved several actors and evolved over time. Therefore, it is likely that multiple interests always coexisted, while regularly shifting depending on the circumstances. What we can be sure of is that Egypt was not pursuing territorial expansion in the modern sense; there is no evidence of consistent Egyptianization or attempts to fully integrate these regions into "Egypt proper". Similarly, there is no substantial evidence of settler-colonization, as seen instead in parts of Nubia (Buzon and Simonetti 2013).[8] If anything, the opposite was true: the Levant was a significant source of immigrants to Egypt. These movements, both voluntary and forced, included foreign soldiers in the Egyptian army (Candelora 2019), royal hostages (Matić 2015b), exchanges of craftsmen and mercenaries (Singer 2012), and, inevitably, prisoners of war and captives. As for the latter, they were clearly seen as valuable labor; upon arrival in Egypt, they likely underwent some degree of forced "Egyptianization" before being settled in temple and royal estates, becoming a productive part of the Pharaonic economy (Morris 2005, 732–33; 2014; Langer 2021, passim).

[6] See e.g. Höflmayer (2019) for a discussion the uncertain link between late Middle Bronze Age destruction layers and early New Kingdom military campaigns.
[7] For instance, the only voice of a local Levantine woman in the Amarna letters is found in postscripts by the Priestess of the Lady of Byblos, added to king Rib-Adda's letters (see Vidal 2010).
[8] However, this does not negate the imperialistic nature of Egypt's presence in the Levant. Not all empires are settler-colonial, and not all settler-colonial systems are imperial monarchies.

Egypt gained not just labor but also vital resources from the Levant, such as timber from the north and copper and precious stones from the south. The trade in these luxury goods had significant cultural impacts, turning key localities into hubs of interaction, as attested by sites like Byblos in the north (Kilani 2017), or the Wadi Nasib, Wadi Kharib, Timna, and Serabit al-Khadim in the south (Hikade 1998). Imports encompassing wine, oils, perfumes, and luxury items are attested by written sources (see e.g. for wine Gardiner 1947, 233*) and depicted in the so-called tribute scenes (Hallmann 2006; Wang 2022). While consistent evidence for shipments of Levantine agricultural products to Egypt is lacking, the Amarna letters might suggest that Egyptians had control over local harvests and could redistribute them among Levantine rulers, or at least this is what Rib-Adda, king of Byblos, seemed to believe. The Levant served as a key crossroads and gateway for international trade. In my opinion (though others may disagree) this might have been a (if not *the*) primary reason for the Egyptian desire to control the northern Levantine coast, and especially the Akkar plain and the Gap of Homs.
On the one hand, this area was the Levant's most strategic crossroad, connecting north-south coastal routes and inland routes (through the Beqaa) with the key east-west corridor of the Gap of Homs, which linked Cyprus and the Aegean to inland Syria and beyond. On the other hand, Thutmose III's campaigns roughly coincide with the earliest signs of Mycenaean trade with the northern Levant and with Mitannian Inner Syria, as indicated by Late Helladic I pottery imports found in the Levant and the Northern Levantine goods found in mainland Greece (Wijngaarden 2002). These commercial interactions intensified during the later 18th dynasty and continued throughout the New Kingdom. For the Egyptians, controlling the Akkar plain would have thus provided a dual benefit: access to the lucrative emerging trade networks and preventing Mitanni from monopolizing this strategic route. Egypt's interest in luxury goods from distant lands is well-attested in texts, tomb depictions, and artifacts. "Deliveries" (*ỉnw*) from regions like Babylon, the Hittite Empire, and the unidentified Asy and Tanaya are listed in Thutmose III's Annals, while exotic items are depicted in various private and royal tombs and monuments (Redford 2003; Hallmann 2006). The Amarna letters also mention caravans and stress the obligation of great kings to ensure their safe passage. Archaeological finds support these written and visual records, revealing the material reality behind these luxury imports. Noteworthy examples include Syrian glass vessels from the tomb of Thutmose III's foreign wives and various Aegean and Cypriot items found all across Egypt (Lilyquist 2003; Barrett 2010; Matić 2015a). The Uluburun shipwreck further highlights their commercial significance in the Eastern Mediterranean (Podany 2012, 255–58). It is clear that the archaeological record is incomplete, and the written and visual sources are often formulaic and ideologically driven, and therefore cannot be regarded as entirely historically accurate. However, the attention these records pay to luxury items from outside Egypt, as opposed to the invisibility of imported common goods (e.g. agricultural products), offers precious insights into the values and ideals of the Egyptian elites, as it reveals what they considered prestigious and worth showcasing about their involvement in the Levant. In this perspective, the northern Levant appears more significant (or more prestigious) than the southern Levant, as shown by its prominence in various written and visual sources. For instance, expeditions to Byblos are frequently mentioned in royal and private texts throughout the New Kingdom (Kilani 2017), while nothing comparable exist for the southern Levant (see also Höflmayer 2015). Obviously, the Egyptian claims likely represent just one ideologically-defined facet of a complex reality. However, archaeological findings support the north's dominant role in Egypt-Levantine trade, even before the New Kingdom. For example, recent studies show that most Levantine pottery found in Second Intermediate Period layers of Avaris came from the northern Levant, not the south (Mourad 2021, 45–72). Economic considerations, however, were certainly not the sole motivations behind Egypt's engagement in the Levant. The sophisticated and dynamic military and administrative infrastructures reflect Egypt's awareness of the region's political and strategic importance. Thutmose III's attack on Megiddo through the Aruna pass and Ramses II's march to Qadesh, involving scouts,

counterespionage, and coordination along coastal and inland routes, demonstrate the Egyptian proficiency in complex military strategic thinking and their appreciation of the importance of knowing and controlling key territorial features.
Finally, more intangible factors related to collective narratives and ideology may have also played a role. For instance, historians already in ancient times have suggested that Roman expansionism was partly driven by the trauma of the Gallic invasions and Punic Wars, leading Roman elites to pursue preemptive conquests to establish buffer zones (Zangani 2023, 64–69 with refs). Similarly, Zangani (2023) proposes that Egypt's territorial ambitions in the Levant could have been influenced and even triggered by the trauma of the partition of Egypt during the Second Intermediate Period and of the emergence of Avaris as a powerful entity politically detached from the contemporary Egyptian reality. While I think it would be too simplistic to attribute everything to a single ideological factor or historical trauma, I agree this dimension warrants careful consideration. Collective ideologies and narratives about traumatic events can indeed shape and be used to justify geopolitical dynamics, as seen even today. More in general, given the significant role narratives and ideologies play in defining how societies engage with the external world, it is worth briefly exploring the main ideological frameworks that influenced the Egyptian interactions with the Levant.

Egyptian Ideological Frames about the Levant

Naturally, ideology in New Kingdom Egypt is a vast subject, too complex to fully explore here. Instead, I will briefly address a few key aspects and narratives relevant to Egyptian-Levantine relations.[9] Egypt's ideological engagement with the Levant can be divided into two main categories: justifications for military actions and explanations for non-military interactions. Two elements were central to these narratives: the King's role as maintainer of cosmic order and as divine link between gods and humans, and an inherently Egyptocentric worldview (Loprieno 2001, 64–74; Baines 2007, 14), which depicted foreigners at Egypt's borders as wicked and dangerous, while imagining faraway lands in the north, east, and south as "God's Lands," inhabited by friendly, positively exotic peoples (Cooper 2011; Kilani 2016; 2017, 222–30).

Narratives of Conflict

In ancient Egypt, kingship ideology depicted the king as both the defender of Egypt and a proactive conqueror, responsible for repelling chaos and subduing wilderness, often symbolized by wild animals and hostile peoples. Central to this narrative was the king's duty to "expand the borders" of Egypt, a concept that first emerged in the Middle Kingdom and persisted, with significant developments, throughout the New Kingdom (Galán 1995, 40:101–35; Kilani 2016, 78; 2017, 224).
Military campaigns were the most obvious way to fulfil the king's duty of "expanding the borders". In some periods the outcome of campaigns—conquests or raids—was secondary; for some kings, simply marching outside of Egypt was enough to claim they had "expanded the borders" (Kilani 2016, 78). Moreover, military ventures were not the only way for a king to fulfill this duty. Any royal action that could be portrayed as securing the submission of a foreign entity could also serve this purpose. This logic underlies, for instance, Hatshepsut's claim of having "expanded the borders" of Egypt after her expedition to Punt. The exotic goods brought back were framed as tributes, symbolizing the submission of the Puntites and thus implying the "expansion of the borders" to the edges of the world (Kilani 2016, 79; 2017, 225 with refs).

[9] I will not discuss here the question of the role and perception of foreigners in Egyptian literature and society, as that question would be too strictly Egyptological for this paper.

Hatshepsut's claims illustrate another aspect of this phenomenon peculiar to the Early New Kingdom: claims regarding border expansions became a race among monarchs, with increasingly grandiose and fictional assertions, involving references to the conquest of semi-mythical places like the "God's Lands" of Punt and Byblos, and mythical locations like the pillars of the sky (Kilani 2016, 79; 2017, 225 with refs).

All this changed with Thutmose III, who not only claimed to have reached distant lands like Byblos but also effectively brought them under Egyptian control. And then he moved on, bringing Egypt in direct, regular contact with other regional powers, like the Mitannian and Hittite empires (Kilani 2016, 80–85; 2017, 226–30). Moreover, following his victories, an agreement with Mitanni, brokered by Amenhotep II, ushered in a period of peace lasting until the end of the 18th dynasty.[10] These conquests, and the following international peace, facilitated interactions, bringing new people, goods, techniques, and likely ideas to Egypt (see Mourad 2021). Simultaneously, Egypt could no longer claim to be the sole kingdom in a chaotic world, as it had to engage diplomatically with powerful neighbouring states. This shift likely impacted Egyptian ideology; for instance, the disappearance of references to Byblos as a "God's Land" after Thutmose III is hardly coincidental: it is hard to see how Lebanon's idealized image as a distant, exotic, mythical land could persist once it became a province of the empire (Kilani 2016, 84–85; 2017, 229–30).

Likewise, it is probably no coincidence that the Amarna revolution, with its universalistic ideas about Egypt's role in the world, emerged after Amenhotep III's reign, during the height of peace and multicultural exchanges. This period of peace must have also prompted changes in how Egyptian kings asserted their role as the upholder of cosmic order. With diplomatic treaties preventing extensive military campaigns, late 18th dynasty Pharaohs had to find new ways to legitimize their rule. I believe one possible solution may lie in the tribute scenes found in 18th dynasty tombs, where foreigners present exotic goods to the Pharaoh (Hallmann 2006; Wang 2022). These scenes were likely inspired by real events where kings received tributes, and gained popularity under Hatshepsut and Thutmose III, becoming increasingly standardized afterwards. While their historicity is debated, the ideological message they conveyed is clear: the king's success in establishing divine order attracted foreigners from all corners of the world to honour his power and that of Egypt and its gods (Wang 2022). in the absence of new territories to conquer, the kings of the late 18th dynasty turned the influx of exotic goods and foreign delegations into a symbolic substitute for military conquests, using them as a new way to claim an expansion of the cosmic order. The universalization of Egypt's worldview and the king's shift from defender/conqueror to receiver of exotic (and divine) gifts fully manifested in the Amarna period (Assmann 1995). Akhenaten's religious reforms, starting from the abandonment of the traditional pantheon of gods, including those associated with military campaigns like Amun, radically altered the ideological narratives surrounding the Levant. It is likely no coincidence that his reign saw very little, if any, Egyptian military activity in the Levant. While depictions of Egyptian armed forces are common in both royal and private Amarnian art, suggesting the army's retained its importance within Egypt, portrayals of Akhenaten as a conquering warrior are notably rare, which may indicate that military conquests held little value in the Amarnian royal narratives (Schulman 1964, 51–52). In contrast, the Ramesside period (19th–20th Dynasties) saw the restoration of traditional religious and ideological ideals, including the centrality of military campaigns to asserting royal legitimacy (Maderna-Sieben 2018). In this renewed war-oriented ideology, any enemy was seen as a suitable target – from Shasu nomads and local rebels (e.g., Seti I's Shasu campaign – Murnane 1990, 40–42) to empires like that of the Hittites (Ramses II - Guidotti and Pecchioli Daddi

[10]At the local level, however, Egyptians may have still launched campaigns to suppress rebellions and maintain dominance.

2002), and foreign threats such as Libyan and seafaring groups (e.g., Merenptah and Ramses III – Hasel 1998; James 2017).
These new wars had both geopolitical and ideological dimensions, as evidenced by the fact that texts recording them are primarily (though not exclusively) found in temples and shrines and often include divine interventions. Thus, the Levant and its populations, in addition to serving as a space for Egyptian imperialism, played once again a central role in shaping the Egyptian kingship and worldview. Notably, tribute scenes become less common during the Ramesside period (Hallmann 2006), which may support the idea that they served as an ideological replacement for military campaigns in the late 18th dynasty—this suggestion, however, would need further research.

Narratives of Peaceful Interactions

Diplomacy was a key aspect of realpolitik in the Late Bronze Age Levant (Liverani 1990; Aruz, Benzel, and Evans 2008). The Egyptians engaged in diplomatic relations, formalized through oaths, treaties, marriages, and gift exchanges, with both great kings and local rulers in their controlled territories. Ideological narratives were crucial in shaping both the practical aspects and the Egyptian public representation of these interactions.
When engaging with Levantine actors, Egypt appears to have embraced, at least partially, the Near Eastern household metaphor (Liverani 1983; Cohen 1996). This metaphor depicted relations among kings of equal rank as exchanges among "brothers" and suzerain-vassal relations as "father-son" relationships. This frame is evident in the international correspondence (Liverani 1983) and in Egyptian literary compositions (Chantrain 2022a; 2022b). However, no trace of this metaphor appears in Egyptian royal inscriptions. There, the narrative is one and the same: the Egyptian king is the centre of the world, and interacts with foreigners only to destroy them or to grant them "the breath of life" after receiving their gifts and (real or imagined) pleas for submission (Davies 2018). Similarly, while international trade is mentioned in the Amarna letters, it is completely invisible in Egyptian sources until the very end of the New Kingdom. Instead, Egyptian sources (both royal and private) focus on the *reception* of goods from various foreign lands, while any mention of *payment* or *compensation* from the Egyptians is consistently omitted (Gordon 1984). After all, everything is owed to the Pharaoh, who owes nothing to any mortal, especially not to any foreigner.
The only consistent exceptions are Byblos and Punt (although similar dynamics might have applied elsewhere - see Morris 2015a; 2015b). Both these lands held a unique status in the Egyptian imagination, as demonstrated by the mention in Egyptian sources of goods sent *from* Egypt *toward* them (cf. Cooper 2011). However, even in these cases, the references are indirect and embedded in Egyptian ideological narratives: yes, Egypt sends products to Byblos or Punts, but these are framed as "offerings" to the local shrines of Hathor. In other words, what were essentially payments to foreigners were thus reframed as pious acts toward an Egyptian deity residing in a temple abroad (Liverani 1990, 240–54; Morris 2015a, 325–27; 2015b; see also Diego Espinel 2002 for the pre-New Kingdom origins of this frame).
This changes in the *Tale of Wenamun* (Schipper 2005), where an Egyptian envoy offers to the king of Byblos Amun's blessings as sole payment for wood. The king, however, rejects this offer, forcing Pharaoh Smendes to intervene and send a proper payment. This shift from no mention of reciprocal trade in previous texts to explicit trade with a foreign king dictating terms in *Wenamun* is noteworthy. Some have interpreted the *Tale of Wenamun* as a rare, honest Egyptian admission of their loss of power in the Levant at the end of the New Kingdom (see Sass 2002 for an overview, with refs; see also, in general Schipper 2005). I would be more cautious: this is a possibility, but not the only one. As mentioned, while mutual diplomatic interactions appear in international correspondence and literary texts, they are notably absent from both royal and non-royal public contexts. This pattern is suspiciously similar to trade,

which is absent in public contexts but found in international correspondence and in the *Tale of Wenamun*, a literary work. Therefore, the apparent contrast between Wenamun and earlier texts could be simply due to differences in genre, and to the lack of comparable stories from earlier periods. As it is often the case, Egyptian sources are substantial enough to suggest the existence of interesting socio-cultural phenomena, but too scanty to fully understand the nature of what we are observing.

Who was there? The Levantine Socio-cultural Landscape

Finally, any discussion of Egypt's interactions with the Levant cannot be complete without considering the people who inhabited the region, their self-perception, and how the Egyptians viewed them. However, collective identities are complex and it is especially challenging to explore them in antiquity due to both theoretical and practical issues. Identities are shaped by perspective—how we see ourselves and how we perceive others (and vice versa). Moreover, collective identities are not monolithic or static; they are diverse and continually evolving within the communities embodying them. This is because collective identities are not material or biological realities (M. Fischer et al. 2019); they are social constructs shaped by shared perceptions and, as Barth noted about ethnicity, defined by sociocultural boundaries (Barth 1969; Eriksen and Jakoubek 2020). This means that while different cultures might share similar identity frameworks, assuming this *a priori* is incorrect. Cultures can have distinct identity frames or assign different significance to the same aspects of identity. It is also important for scholars today to recognize that contemporary identity frames (e.g. "racial", "ethnic", "national") are not universal but specific to modern societies. As such, these categories may have been secondary or even completely irrelevant in the Ancient Near East, where societies likely operated along different identity lines—just as some societies continue to do today. These theoretical considerations have practical implications when studying ancient societies (e.g. Brather 2004). To begin with, this means that to effectively understand collective identities, one must rely on what individuals who identify with them tell us about them. This, in turn, implies that written sources are our primary and most reliable means of gathering information about collective identities in ancient societies. In other words, since collective identities are society-specific constructs, it is illusory to believe that we can accurately understand how people perceived themselves in the past without written sources. Archaeology, linguistics, and genetics attest of the existence of multiple clusters of people characterized by distinct practices, languages, or biological ancestries all across the Levant. However, it would be wrong to assume *a priori* that these clusters corresponded to specific, explicitly perceived collective identities. As archaeologists have long argued, pots are not people, or at least they cannot be assumed *a priori* to be so (Brather 2004). The same applies to languages and genes: while some groups with a shared identity may also share language, genetic ancestry, and material culture, many communities (possibly the majority) clearly do not (Barbieri et al. 2022).

In fact, even contemporary societies clearly show that people can share a same identity even though they speak different languages or have different ancestries (Switzerland is a good modern example of that), while at the same time there are also plenty of examples of people speaking the same language or share the same ancestry who however identify with distinct or even opposing identities. The biblical world illustrates these issues well. Modern linguistics classifies Hebrew and Canaanite as closely related languages, and references to a "Semitic" culture and identity are common in scholarship.[11] However, the Bible classifies the Israelites as descendants of Shem = "Semites" while it describes the Canaanites, along with Egyptians and other African people, as descendants of Cham = "Chamites" (Gen. 5, 10, 11). This shows that

[11]And appallingly even to a "Semitic race", terrible modern echoes of the darkest moments of modern Western history.

for the Iron Age Israelites, linguistic similarity did not imply shared ethnic identity, nor did the difference between Canaanite and Egyptian languages stop them from envisioning a common "Chamitic" ancestry. Given all this, what can we say about the collective identities of the Levant's inhabitants? Contemporary local texts are crucial to explore this question, and although they are scares and often vague, they do provide important insights. In particular, Mynářová (2022, esp. 300-301) observes that while the Amarna letters reference various groups, none are defined in obvious ethnic terms; instead, they are categorized by region or city-state (i.e. through *demonyms*,[12] rather than *ethnonyms*), or by occupation and lifestyle. This matches the Ugaritic documents (Pardee and Bordreuil 1992), where individuals are mainly identified by family, and secondarily by profession, geographical origins, or geopolitical affiliations.[13] New Kingdom Egyptian texts show a similar pattern (Kilani 2023), as people from the Near East are mostly identified by their association with cities, regions, or kingdoms, using *demonyms* rather than traditional ethnic labels.[14] The only exceptions are groups existing or originating beyond Egyptian-recognized geopolitical realities, like nomads, mercenaries and sea marauders. However, the terms used for these latter groups likely refer to social roles, not ethnic identities (see e.g. the *ʿpr* ~ *ḫapiru*,[15] as discussed also in Mynářová 2022), and they often reflect purely Egyptian perspectives rather than local identities.[16] Therefore, the sources provide clear evidence of a division between settled populations (cities, farmers) and marginal groups (nomads, outcasts),[17] further defined by political, social, and familial affiliations. In contrast, the absence of 'ethnic identities' is significant, suggesting that they may be a modern mirage with little bearing on the realities of the ancient Near East.

Moreover, collective identities in the ancient Near East were certainly fluid, as well illustrated by Idrimi's 15th-century BCE biography (Greenstein 1976). Born into the ruling elite of Aleppo, he became a *ḫapiru* after his family's fall from power, living as an outcast in Canaan. Eventually, he gathered followers, returned to northern Syria, conquered Alalakh, and reclaimed his status as a ruler. The genesis of the kingdom of Amurru offers a similar example (Singer 1991). Established by people likely living on society's margins in the northern Lebanese mountains, its rulers managed to conquer a significant territory and emerged as a major regional power in a short time (Goren, Finkelstein, and Naʾaman 2003). Notably, the West-Semitic and Hurrian linguistic backgrounds of the names of the rulers of Amurru, suggest fluid linguistic and identity landscapes (Singer 1991, 159). These cases point to a complex reality in which mobility between groups and collective identities was possible , although the extent of such occurrences remains uncertain.[18] Recent genetic studies point in the same direction: various international and Israeli studies (see e.g. Nebel et al. 2000; Hammer et al. 2000; Kopelman et al. 2009) suggest that modern Palestinians are characterized both by a strong genetic connection with modern Jewish communities and in turn with the ancient Bronze and Iron Age populations of the Southern Levant, as well as by genetic elements coming from interactions with and

[12]See the definition in the Merriam-Webster dictionary (https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/demonym)

[13] E.g. the term *msry* = "Egyptian" carry a geopolitical meaning, referring to someone from Egypt, rather than an ethnic identity.

[14] Some terms that could be interpreted as tribal, ethnic, or para-ethnic labels (e.g. *fnḫw* = coastal Levantine populations) do appear in New Kingdom religious and poetic texts. However, these are traditional terms, already attested in the Old Kingdom; therefore, in New Kingdom texts, they are better understood as relics of an older identity system rather than as part of a contemporary, primary identity framework.

[15] I will not address here the the thorny issue of the connection between *hapiru* and *Hebrew*, as it extends into the Iron Age and lacks sufficient evidence for firm conclusions. For a comprehensive critique, see Astour (1999).

[16] Such the Egyptian word *šꜣsw* = "Levantine nomads", likely derived from Egyptian *šꜣs* = "to stroll".

[17] Interestingly, Matić (2022) notes that Egyptian sources use *wr.w* for leaders of settled communities and *ꜥ.w* for leaders on the margins.

[18] See also the Egyptian tales of Sinuhe and the Doomed Prince, which depict Egyptians leaving the Nile Valley, integrating into the Levant, and adapting to local realities. While fictional, these stories highlight the recurrence of this theme in contemporary narratives.

immigration from outside populations at various points in time (Nebel et al. 2001; see also Agranat-Tamir et al. 2020 for the same pattern across the wider Near East). These patterns highlight a dynamic, fluid sociocultural landscape in which local populations have never been entirely supplanted by new migratory waves; instead, they have continuously integrated newcomers and shifted between different languages, cultures, religions, and collective identities over the ages, often not concurrently. While some people likely transtioned between identities due to individual choices and opportunities, others were forced to do so. For instance, Ramses III claims to have settled Libyan prisoners in Egyptian strongholds, to have "turned their tongues", forcing them to learn the Egyptian language (Morris 2005, 731–33; Langer 2021, 285–86).

Moreover, it is interesting to observe that certain cultural and linguistic traditions might have been strongly linked to specific social classes. For example, Mitanni's rulers had Indo-Aryan names, a linguistic tradition also seen among some Levantine rulers in the Amarna letters. However, there is no sign of an "Indo-Aryan" ethnic identity in the sources. At the same time, the geographical distribution of these names in the Amarna letters is noteworthy, as they appear (along with Hurrian names) to be primarily carried by rulers from regions targeted by Egyptian military campaigns under Thutmose III and Amenhotep II (Kilani 2020a; 2020b).[19] Moving away from modern ethnic frameworks, we might consider that these names reflected a socio-cultural identity, possibly resembling a caste system. If so, an Indo-Aryan name could have been more of a marker of social status, ruling class affiliation,[20] and cultural or geopolitical ties (as part of the Hurro-Mitannian sphere, and thus politically opposed to Egypt at the time of the wars with Mitanni), rather than being an "ethnic" marker (a sociocultural dynamic already suggested by Singer 1991, 159 - see below; see also Agranat-Tamir et al. 2020, 1154). This hypothesis offers a strong interpretative frame for similar patterns attested elsewhere in the Ancient Near East. For example, it could explain changes in the linguistic affiliation of rulers' names within the same dynasty[21] not as shifts in ethnic identity but as indicators of geopolitical realignments. In this respect, the case of Amurru is particularly suggestive: while early rulers had West-Semitic names, successors bore Hurro-Hittite names after Aziru defected from Egypt and aligned with the Hittites (Singer 1991, 177). Singer (1991, 159) saw this as a political statement by the ruling class of Amurru reflecting their new geopolitical orientations.

Going back to the Egyptian terms for Levantine groups, an interesting phenomenon appears in 19th and 20th dynasty texts. While the primary identity frame remains geopolitical, these texts start using specific, non-Egyptian names for people outside Egyptian-controlled areas, such as non-sedentary Libyan and Levantine groups, or the Sea Peoples. Interestingly, several of these names persist and later become integral to the later Iron Age eastern Mediterranean landscape. Notably, among them we find the name *y-s-ʾr-iỉ-rỉ* attested once in a stele of Merneptah, which is widely understood as the earliest and only Egyptian attestation of Israel (see e.g. Hasel 1994; Rainey 2001), and the name *pʷ-ʾr-sỉ-tỉ* (and variants – the name is attested several times), attested for the first time in Ramses III's inscriptions in Medinet Habu, which is generally assumed to be the ancestor of the biblical *Pəlīštīm* = Philistines and *Pəlešeṯ* = Philistia, from which also Herodotus' *Palaistinē* (3:91 and elsewhere), as well as medieval (see e.g. Mūsā ibn Sahl al-Ramlī's *Man nazala Filasṭīn min al-ṣaḥābah*, 874 CE), and modern Arabic *Filasṭīniyyūn/Filasṭīn* = Palestinian/Palestine. These names are consistently spelled with classifiers for groups of people ( or), rather than for places (), and the fact that they are

[19] On the possible arrival of Hurrian cultural elements in these inland areas before the New Kingdom see Na'aman 1994; contra: Dever 1998. See also Agranat-Tamir et al. 2020, esp. 1154.

[20] Even in the modern English-speaking world, certain names are perceived as more 'aristocratic' than others. For example, we can imagine a royal child being named William, Charlotte, or Elisabeth, but we would likely be surprised if the name were Colt, Savannah, Jace, or something unconventional like XÆA-12 or Techno Mechanicus.

[21] See e.g. the rulers of Tell Ashtara, Tell es-Safi, or Amurru.

often mentioned in association with each other, often in configurations resembling leagues or confederations suggest that they may have indicated sub-identities within broader macro-identity complexes. This would suggest that during the Late Bronze Age these names were more akin to tribal rather than ethnic names—an idea supported by later Iron Age traditions identifying some of them as, indeed, tribal names, such as the *i͗-q-y-w-š* (and variants) of the Egyptian sources (e.g. *KRI* IV 8:12), who are commonly identified with the Acheans, one of the four main subgroups/tribes of the Greek people (see e.g. Herodotus 8:73).
Yet, some other names, like that of the Philistines, appear as ethnonyms in the Iron Age, thus suggesting a regional shift from identities based on geopolitical and sociocultural ties to new identites rooted in tribal or ethnic affiliations. This transition can be interpreted in two ways. One possibility is that it represents a totally new sociocultural development that took place at the end of the Late Bronze Age, potentially introduced by incoming groups. Alternatively, it could reflect a change in prominence between two coexisting identity systems. In the latter case, one could imagine that during the Late Bronze Age the geopolitical framework was favoured by the elites, who had the monopoly on textual production, while tribal identities existed in non-elite, non-literate contexts. However, during the transition to the Iron Age, previously marginalized groups rose to become new literate elites, thus bringing their tribal identities into prominence in written records. While I lean towards the latter option, the scarcity of evidence prevents a definitive conclusion–both scenarios remain plausible, with historical parallels even in modern times.[22] What is clear is that the transition from the Bronze to the Iron Age marked a significant reorganization of identities in the Levant and Eastern Mediterranean, with Egyptian sources from the 19th and 20th dynasties offering early evidence for it. However, the processes and factors driving these changes still require further research.

The End of the Egyptian Domination

The end of the New Kingdom corresponds to the collapse of the Egyptian control in the area. Unfortunately, the lack of explicit sources for this period makes it difficult to trace how the process unfolded, and which factors triggered and shaped it. From generalized regional collapses, to internal dynastic troubles, from droughts and earthquakes to migrations and social upheavals, plenty of reasons have been adduced, argued for, and dismissed (see e.g. Bachhuber and Roberts 2009; Cline 2014; P. M. Fischer and Bürge 2017; Millek 2021 among many others). Discussing all this would go way beyond the scope of this chapter. It is enough to say here that the endless debates surrounding the last major event of the period, namely Ramses III's battle against the Sea People, are very illustrative of this state of affairs (James 2017 with refs). What the Egyptians claim is that they fought two battles, one on land and one at sea, against a coalition of "Sea Peoples". They reportedly won both battles, capturing many prisoners and settling them in Egyptian fortresses. The land battle is said to have taken place in northern Lebanon, near Amurru, while the sea battle occurred at the mouth of an unnamed river. We also know that in later periods, individuals linked to the Sea Peoples are attested along the Levantine coast, as far south as Gaza. Everything else, however, is and has been subject of debate: Did Egypt truly win, or was it merely propaganda? Did the sea battle occur near Amurru, with captives settled in Levantine strongholds still controlled by Egypt? Or had Egypt already lost control of the Levant, and the battle was fought in the Delta? Or could the Sea Peoples' settlement on the Levantine coast be due to a separate later (or earlier?) event? The truth is, we do not know, and recent scholarship is increasingly acknowledging and come to terms with this fact. Once we move away from the quest for elusive grand narratives, it becomes easier to appreciate the

[22] For example, consider the shift from *ius soli* to *ius sanguinis* in European countries during the 19th and 20th centuries, driven by internal changes. In contrast, the introduction of *ius sanguinis* in Africa and other former colonies was largely a result of European colonial influence (Perelló 2018).

unique complexities of this transitional period, shaped by internal and external factors and marked by significant political, economic, and socio-cultural changes.

Conclusions

During the New Kingdom, Egypt's interactions with the Levant were shaped by a complex interplay of military, diplomatic, economic, and ideological factors. The region's strategic importance, particularly in the north, made it a vital trade gateway and a key point of contact with neighbouring empires. Crucially, Egyptian activities, ranging from raids to diplomacy and trade, were influenced by both strategic interests and ideological frameworks, and dynamically adapted to broader geopolitical shifts and internal changes. The Levant was significantly impacted by these dynamics, but it was not only a passive recipient of Egyptian domination; local entities actively engaged in a dynamic dialogue across socio-cultural spaces.
As for the Southern Levant, it may not have been the primary focus of Egyptian interests, but it undeniably played an integral role in these dynamics. However, understanding its role in this complex context presents unique challenges due to both the nature of the sources and modern biases. The region's association with biblical narratives has undeniably fuelled significant scholarly interest and archaeological research. However, this focus, often shaped more by Western-specific ideas and traditions than by data-driven considerations, has also contributed to a distorted view of the region. The southern Levant has been overstudied and overemphasized, often overshadowing neighbouring areas. This distortion affects both our understanding of the region and its role within the broader context, making it essential to adopt a more comprehensive view of the entire region in order to fully grasp the development of the southern Levant's history and sociocultural landscape during the Late Bronze Age. Addressing these biases is crucial for achieving a more balanced and nuanced understanding of the southern Levant's interactions, history, and sociocultural landscape during the Late Bronze Age. Fortunately, the field is moving in this direction, thus offering promising insights into the region's past.

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